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THE MIDDLE CLASSES

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In 1920, Kurt Tucholsky, one of the most important journalists in the Weimar Republic, mused in the magazine *Die Weltbühne*: “It is odd, this bourgeoisie. ... Odd in its rigid adherence to forms that are void, to things that actually do not exist anymore. ... The era of the bourgeoisie is over. Nobody knows what will come next” (Tucholsky 1920, 333f.). Tucholsky’s predicament was tragically confirmed 13 years later with the rise to power of the National Socialists. On February 21, 1933, just a week before being illegally arrested by the Nazis, Carl von Ossietzky (who was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1936 and died in 1938 after years of mistreatment in German concentration camps) confirmed in the very same magazine Tucholsky’s claim: “The bourgeois is broke, his ideals are scattered to the four winds” (Ossietzky 1933, 285).

These two quotations are certainly a predictor of the socio-political turmoil that shook Germany in the interwar years. But beyond that, they may also be considered evidence for the crisis of middle-class culture that contemporaries noticed in various European countries in the face of economic troubles, the intensification of class conflict, the enduring critique of parliamentary democracy, and the rise of mass culture in the interwar years. The First World War had fundamentally shattered the expectation of social progress and civilizational progress, ideals of which the bourgeoisie considered itself to be the embodiment. To some extent, the war had been functional as a catalyst which had laid open the internal contradictions that had characterized the bourgeois world since the late nineteenth century. This had at least been the opinion of Tucholsky who had stated in 1920 that “the first of August 1914 has only sped up what has been in the process of rolling anyway. A quiet rolling—and now it collapses” (Tucholsky 1920, 333).

While the crisis of European bourgeois culture has been noted in several publications (Hobsbawm 1987; Mommsen 2004), this contribution aims to also explore the history of the middle classes in other parts of the world, beyond Europe. It will point out that the interwar years brought about social changes in Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and the Americas that affected the middle classes in these areas. In some cases, members of the respective middle classes had a hand in influencing these developments, whose consequences, however, were often unforeseen. In other cases, they were the victims of political and economic transformations that were beyond their control. Many of these developments were triggered

by the outcome of the Great War; this was obviously the case in Europe but also in the colonial world, where the Ottoman Empire dissolved and national independence movements strengthened in several European colonies (Manela 2007). The First World War was indeed a global moment; however, its effect varied in different parts of the world and was much greater in Europe, Asia, the Middle East, and North Africa than in the Americas and sub-Saharan Africa because the war and the ensuing decline of imperial power, respectively, had a much greater effect in the former areas than in the latter.

This essay is organized into five Sections. The first Section presents recent research on the rise of middle classes in the long nineteenth century and argues for the global application of the terms “bourgeoisie” and “middle classes,” which were initially devised to describe Western societies. The following Sections will give an overview on the history of the middle classes in Europe (Section ‘Europe: The End of the Bourgeois Era’), South Asia, Africa, and the Middle East (Section ‘Middle Classes in the Colonial World’), China and Japan (Section ‘The Different Fate of the Middle Classes in Japan and China’), and the Americas (Section ‘The Americas: Contestation between Bourgeoisie and Middle Classes’). The global history of the middle classes is a rather new field of research that only began to consolidate in recent years (López and Weinstein 2012; Dejung, Motadel, and Osterhammel 2019). In particular, the history of bourgeois groups differed remarkably in various countries and also within the respective countries it varied in different cities. Therefore, any reference to the history of middle classes in particular areas can only have an exploratory character and will have to be tested by further research. However, the contribution suggests the value of social history in framing the global history of the interwar era, as well as arguing for global social history as a distinct approach (Dejung 2019b). It thus complements, by focusing on the middle classes, research initiatives that have explored the consequences of global entanglements on social strata such as the aristocracy (Motadel 2011), the peasantry (Vanhaute 2021), or the working classes (van der Linden 2008).

The Rise of the Middle Classes in the Age of Empire

For a long time, social historians were convinced that there were no social formations beyond the North Atlantic world that could be compared to the European or North American bourgeoisies and middle classes in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries (Siegrist 2001, 1312). Recent scholarship, however, has identified the emergence of social formations that can be compared to the Euro-American middle class in places as different as China, India, Peru, Egypt, and sub-Saharan Africa (Bergère 1989; Parker 1998; West 2002; Watenpaugh 2006; Pernau 2013; Ryzova 2014; Abou-Hodeib 2017). A fundamental challenge was creating a definition of middle class that is applicable worldwide. In contrast to the aristocracy or the working class, the bourgeois middle class could neither be characterized by well-defined privileges acquired by birth or a particular political agenda, nor could they be distinguished clearly from other social groups by their socioeconomic status. This problem was discussed among social historians of Europe during the twentieth century and has now grown even more acute.

A particular problem of a comparative history of the middle classes is that the designations of this group in different languages—such as *middle classes* in English, *Bürgertum* in German, *classe moyenne* in French, *efendiyya* in Arabic, or *bhadralok* in Bengali—often have different meanings and connotations. Historians have already discussed this problem of semantic heterogeneity in the European context, and it becomes even more crucial in a global comparison, where historians are confronted with more than just “three bourgeois worlds,” i.e. the

German *Bürgertum*, the English middle class and the French *classe moyenne* and *bourgeoisie*, respectively (Koselleck, Spree, and Steinmetz 1991). For practical reasons, then, and if not stated otherwise, the terms “bourgeoisie” and “middle class” will be used interchangeably in this contribution, acknowledging the different meanings and connotations both terms carry in different English-speaking societies and, more crucially, the problems of using a European term as a category to analyze non-European societies.

European social historians presented a pragmatic solution to the dilemma of how to conceive the middle class. They pointed out that the affiliation to this social group depended not least on the acceptance of a specific moral-cultural canon and a certain way of living. It was the adoption of particular manners, specific clothing, the development of an individual personality, the belief in progress, and a distinct gender order (Ryan 1981; Mann 1985; Davidoff and Hall 1987; Frevert 1989; Jacob 2010) that resulted in the merging of professionals, intellectuals, and businessmen into one discernible social cohort (Hettling and Hoffmann 2000; Young 2003; Seigel 2012). Such a perspective proves to be suitable for global histories of the middle classes as well. Middling sorts throughout the non-Western world shared much with the Western middle classes in terms of their cultural orientation (López and Weinstein 2012; Dejung, Motadel, and Osterhammel 2019). The middle classes that emerged throughout the long nineteenth century (c. 1750–1914) were intrinsically linked to globalization. They were in many ways the product of global entanglements. This is certainly true for middle classes in Europe’s colonies, often educated in missionary schools or Western local schools. Looking at the emergence of the Indian middle classes as an exemplary case, scholars argued that this group had developed their hegemony within local society from a position of colonial subalternity. Moreover, they have claimed that the social identity of these groups relied often on an imitation of Western archetypes; Partha Chatterjee (1986, 1993) argues that it had to be perceived as a “derivative discourse.”

This notion has been challenged lately. Sanjay Joshi (2001) argues that the emergence of an Indian middle class cannot be reduced to an adoption of Western discourses of progress and modernization. Such a notion in his eyes disregards the agency of this social group and does not consider the fact that their self-fashioning relied on vernacular notions of political and social organization. Indeed, the emergence of middle-class cultures was often a complex process of negotiation and renegotiation within and between different societies, instead of the simple adaptation of a given canon. Similar processes can be observed all over the non-Western world. Accordingly, the emergence of non-Western middle classes can be interpreted as a hybrid mix of local traditions and influences from abroad.

A similar case can be made for the European middle classes. As recent works have shown their cultural formation was not a case *sui generis* but drew on global interactions as well (Cooper and Stoler 1997). Business elites, which were an integral part of the European bourgeoisie, generally were part of global economic networks (Jones 1987; Dejung 2018). What is more, bourgeois culture relied on the consumption of commodities imported from colonial possessions, such as sugar, tea, cocoa, coffee, or silk, and it involved the contemplation of exotic plants and animals by visiting zoological and botanical gardens (Hall and Rose 2006). European middle classes also regularly sustained their notion of modernity by comparing the stage of development that Western civilization had reached to that of allegedly “primitive” societies in colonial fringes (Kuklick 2008). The emergence of middle classes in different parts of the world can thus be seen as a consequence of global entanglements rather than the diffusion of a European bourgeois lifestyle all over the world. This exchange process, however, did not take place on a level playing field, but in the context of Western dominance and imperialism. Colonial middle classes, time and time again, saw their claim for political rights

and their aspiration for being part of a global process of modernization inhibited by imperial hubris and racism. And whereas colonial middle classes generally took the European middle classes as a yardstick, the opposite was obviously not true.

The interwar years are a particularly revealing era to examine the middle classes. Whereas the period before 1914 was characterized by the hegemony of bourgeois culture in Western Europe (and the East Coast of the United States) on the one hand and the (often futile) attempts of middle classes in the rest of the world to modernize their countries according to the Western model on the other, the interwar years provided a much more fragmented picture. The consequences of the Great War shattered the confidence of the European bourgeoisie, and the middle classes in the global South began to distance themselves from the European model of development as they increasingly began to support anticolonial liberation movements.

Europe: The End of the Bourgeois Era

The Great War ended an era in social history. For historian Eric Hobsbawm (1987, 6), “[it] was felt to be the end of an era at the time, and it is still felt to be so;” August 1914 “mark[ed] the end of the world made by and for the bourgeoisie.” In a similar vein, German historian Wolfgang J. Mommsen subtitled his study on the First World War “The beginning of the end of the bourgeois era” (2004).

Such verdicts might seem surprising given that the end of the war spelled the end of monarchic power throughout much of Europe. In countries such as Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Russia, monarchies had been overturned at the end of the war and replaced by republican forms of government, or a socialist dictatorship in the case of the newly established Soviet Union. In other countries, such as Italy, Sweden, Britain, Denmark, and Spain, although aristocratic elites formally maintained political control, monarchic power declined significantly in the interwar years (Osterhammel 2014, 750–754). Before the war, in fact, the bourgeoisie had only captured political power in small number of European states, such as Switzerland, the Netherlands, and France. In most other European countries, among them great powers such as Germany, Great Britain, or Austria-Hungary—the middle classes often existed in a symbiotic relationship with the aristocracy, or, in colonial possessions, with the colonial state, without taking over state power themselves (Kocka 2004). After 1918, however, the political influence of the middle classes increased considerably.

Despite the limited influence of the middle classes before 1914, many scholars described the long nineteenth century as the age of the bourgeoisie. They substantiated this claim by pointing out that it was members of this very group who were the proponents of science, education, and the capitalist economy and thus of the driving forces that undermined the socio-political ancien regime and heralded the modern epoch (Palmade 1975; Sperber 1997; Bank and van Buuren 2004). What is more, it was middle-class activists who challenged aristocratic rule in many countries and fought for the establishing of parliamentary democracy. As Eric Hobsbawm (1962) famously maintained, the rise of the middle classes was inextricably linked to the double revolutions of the late eighteenth century: the economic transformations initiated by the British Industrial Revolution on the one hand and the struggle for political participation in the wake of the American and French Revolutions on the other hand. While orthodox Marxists argued for a causal relation between industrialization and the quest for political participation and ultimately took both as the doings of a revolutionary bourgeoisie, Hobsbawm’s analysis was more nuanced. He pointed out that both the American Revolution of 1776 and the French Revolution of 1789 had occurred

before industrial production could have an effect in the respective countries. What is more, nineteenth-century British entrepreneurs could hardly be described as revolutionary. Politically, they came to terms with the aristocracy without much difficulty.

Hobsbawm's account points to the ambiguity of the bourgeois ideology. On the one hand, the middle classes propagated civilizational development that was supposed to raise the educational and economic standard of living of all members of society. On the other hand, the economic position of the middle classes within European societies relied not least on the existence of a working class whose political demands and claims for better working conditions were rebuffed by both governments and middle classes. As a consequence, the political landscape in most European countries was shaped by an intensification of the class conflict, in particular after the 1870s (Hobsbawm 1987, 84–111). The inherent contradictions of the bourgeois project, however, were not only disclosed by the class conflict within European societies but also by the bourgeois gender order which was meant to restrict the role of women to the private sphere. Women's suffrage was only gradually introduced in European countries after the turn of the century (Evans 1977; Richter and Wolff 2018). Further, the relation of Europe to the colonial world revealed further paradoxes within bourgeois ideology, as Frederick Cooper and Ann Laura Stoler (1997) pointed out; after all, colonial racism stood in obvious contrast to the claim of universal equality of all humans propagated by the metropolitan middle classes.

Whereas the hegemony of the middle classes had seemed rather stable up to 1914, the Great War undermined many of the pillars on which the bourgeois worldview was grounded. As a matter of fact, the aftermath of the war laid bare many of these contradictions and spurred change along the axes of class, gender, and colonial rule.

First, the carnage of the trench war seemed to mock any promises about social development by which they had sustained their ambitions and justified their claim for a leading role in society in the long nineteenth century, an era that many contemporaries had described as the “century of progress” (Rydell 1993). The middle classes had not been merely hapless bystanders of the destruction that industrial warfare had brought upon European culture; on the contrary, middle-class intellectuals were among the most zealous supporters of national war efforts across the continent (Mommsen 2004, 19).

Second, the war had not only deteriorated the living conditions of the working classes but also resulted in the relative impoverishment of the middle classes. Middle-class fortunes bankrolled the war effort, as they purchased war bonds that lost most of their value after the war. This resulted in a gradual social decline of the bourgeoisie, and their perceived loss of status led many to support right-wing and fascist parties in the interwar years (Mommsen 2004, 18).

Third, the interwar years resulted in the breakthrough of mass culture. The radio, the cinema, the music hall, and illustrated magazines became available for ever larger parts of the population and challenged the predominance of bourgeois institutions such as the opera or the theatre in metropolitan culture. Many members of the middle class considered the rise of mass culture a symptom of cultural decline and abominable Americanization because North America exported many commercial novelties to Europe after 1918 (Linke and Tanner 2006).

Fourth, the Russian Revolution brought forth a systemic alternative to the liberal model of parliamentary democracy and capitalism. Before the war, the middle classes had confidently looked ahead as there seemed to be no realistic prospect of a socialist or anarchistic revolution in European societies. The Russian Revolution, however, revealed that an overthrow was indeed a possibility within a European empire; the ruthless way the Bolsheviks eliminated the aristocracy, the bourgeoisie, big farmers, and the church was a shock for the Western middle classes. The realization that “bourgeois civil society could

meet with such catastrophic disaster had a chilling effect on middle-class faith in liberalism and democracy” (Mulholland 2012, 173). Socialism thus came to be truly feared among the European bourgeoisie after 1918. Many right-wing intellectuals also were convinced that the era of rationality and individuality that had characterized the long nineteenth century in the wake of the French Revolution was over and that the future would belong to totalitarian mass parties. As they saw it, the era of liberal democracy was over, and the future offered the choice of fascism on the one hand and socialism on the other. This notion became even more popular after the stock market crash of 1929, and ever more members of both the upper classes and the petit bourgeoisie began to support fascist parties in the early 1930s (Mulholland 2012, 173–194).

Fifth, the interwar years saw a growing critique of colonialism. National independence movements emerged in many non-European countries after 1918 and challenged European imperial rule. Educated elites from both the metropolises and the colonies began to ponder alternatives to colonialism that became ever more plausible (Boehmer 2002; Wilder 2005; Boittin 2010; Goebel 2015).

Sixth, a Social-Darwinist ideology ever more challenged the liberal worldview that had been predominant among the European bourgeoisie until the turn of the twentieth century. Oswald Spengler’s *The Decline of the West*, which he began in 1911 and which was first published in 1918, captured the contemporary mood. To illustrate this ideology that occupied the minds of many middle-class intellectuals I would like to cite some of the writings of Eugen Bircher, a right-wing Swiss politician and medical doctor. In 1925, Bircher had published an enthusiastic review of Madison Grant’s dystopian book *The Passing of the Great Race* by pointing out that modern society with its factories, urbanization, and with democracy would, “from a racial point of view,” result in the “survival of the unfittest” (Bircher 1925). Urbanization, which had been the sine qua non of the emergence of the middle classes as a social group, was considered the reason for their decline by many right-wing thinkers after the turn of the twentieth century. In 1940, Bircher reviewed Richard Korherr’s *Volk und Raum* in a Swiss military journal (in 1943, Korherr would be tasked to work out a statistical report on the solution of the “Jewish question” by Heinrich Himmler). In this review, Bircher (1940) wrote:

The introduction of this great and exceptional ... study addresses a problem which ... concerns all of humankind: the problem of population. It points out that we white people have the greatest interest to unite; otherwise we will be overrun and destroyed by the coloured races sooner or later; that the increase of the coloured races has become a coloured flood and that the war of the races from a coloured point of view has come into immediate reach...In addition to that it is revealed that it is urbanisation throughout the world, in Europe and most particularly in Germany that leads to the decline ... of the white people.

The fact that in the interwar years, many right-wing intellectuals regularly linked their anti-Socialist notions with a warning about the peoples of the global South may be considered evidence for a global vision of world order many of these thinkers had on the one hand and evidence for the crisis of the bourgeois worldview in that period on the other (Dejung 2019a). It was only the downfall of Fascism in the Second World War and the postwar recovery that made for a new reconciliation in Western Europe societies. Its consequences on the European bourgeoisie are a topic of debate. Some scholars argue that the breakthrough of consumer society resulted in a decline of the bourgeois values and bourgeois culture as it had

established itself in the long-nineteenth century. Others argue that the period post-1945 saw the general acceptance of parliamentary democracy, and the possibility for social mobility due to an increase of educational institutions and the possibility for ever larger parts of society to acquire consumer goods and thus a dissemination of middle-class ideals and practices throughout society (Budde, Conze, and Rauh 2010).

Middle Classes in the Colonial World

The interwar years also brought about a political shift in the colonial world. The war had weakened European imperial power and resulted in the break-up of the Ottoman Empire. This instability led to both a radicalization of pre-existing national independence movements, as was the case most prominently in India, and the formation of new intellectual circles and movements, which increasingly developed an anticolonial agenda throughout Asia, Africa, and the Middle East. To some extent, this development emerged from anti-colonial nationalists' disappointment that Woodrow Wilson's demand for the self-determination of peoples, put forth in his 1918 speech on war aims and peace terms, did not include the non-Western world (Manela 2007). It must be stressed, however, that anticolonial unrest had intensified already before the war. On the Indian Subcontinent, for instance, many Hindus opposed British plans to partition Bengal in 1905, and there were frequent peasant uprisings against colonial tax regimes and agricultural policy throughout Asia and Africa (Scott 1985).

Colonial middle classes played an important role in this process, both before and after the First World War. Many of the independence movements were founded by members of the educated middle classes. This was the case with the Indian National Congress (established in 1885) but also with many other organizations that came into being in other parts of the colonial world. The exponents of these movements were very well connected internationally; London and Paris functioned as meeting points in which revolutionaries exchanged ideas and influenced each other (Boittin 2010; Goebel 2015). What is more, the resistance against colonial rule created cosmopolitan intellectual cultures, which allowed individuals from different parts of the world to create an anti-imperial repertoire of ideas (Boehmer 2002; Bose and Manjappa 2010; Slate 2012; Manjappa 2014; Krautwald, Lindner, and Nakao 2018).

Nevertheless, it is important not to overrate the significance of colonial middle classes for decolonization. On the one hand, interwar European imperial rule was also contested by Communist activists such as Hồ Chí Minh, who became the first prime minister of Vietnam after the country declared its independence from France in 1945; many of these revolutionaries came from rural areas and cannot be ranked among the middle classes. On the other hand, colonial middle classes were a tiny minority and had by no means the power base to take on European colonizers on their own. Ranajit Guha thus cautioned against the elitism that characterized the nationalist historiography of a country such as India after independence and maintained that the struggle against colonial rule and the establishment of Indian nationalist consciousness did not result from middle-class agency alone. Rather, "the subaltern classes and groups constituting of the mass of the labouring population and the intermediate strata in town and country—that is, the people" made important contributions to the colonial cause (Guha 1988, 40). Their political consciousness, he argued, had developed independently from the intellectual sphere of both the colonial state and the indigenous middle class. However, the political spheres of the middle and the subaltern classes, respectively, did not exist in complete isolation from each other: "there was a great deal of overlap arising precisely from the

effort made from time to time by the more advanced elements among the indigenous elite, especially the bourgeoisie, to integrate them.” Yet,

The braiding together of the two strands of elite and subaltern politics led invariably to explosive situations indicating that the masses mobilized by the elite to fight for their own objectives managed to break away from their control and put the characteristic imprint of popular politics on campaigns initiated by the upper classes.

(Guha 1988, 40f.)

According to such a view, anticolonial nationalism could be interpreted as a synthesis of indigenous middle-class and subaltern political aspirations. In the case of India, Gandhi personifies such an amalgamation: a Western-educated lawyer who wore Western clothes until 1913, he adopted the dress of the poorest Indian, *khadi*, after his return to India as a symbolic rejection of imperial rule and a cultural bridging to the subaltern classes.

Such an approach that considers the agency of both middle classes and subaltern groups seems also applicable to the Middle East and North Africa after the breakup of the Ottoman Empire. In the Middle East, an Arab bourgeoisie established itself at the turn of the twentieth century (Watenpaugh 2006). It comprised merchants, clerks, teachers, doctors, and lawyers who took an interest in the political, scientific, and technological innovations made in Europe and aimed at applying them to the Ottoman Empire (Masters 2013, 195–203). Although this bourgeoisie was successful in establishing civil society institutions, it was not able to seize political power. One reason was certainly the lack of industrialization which prevented the emergence of a viable economic bourgeoisie that could also exert political influence. Another reason was the tensions between Muslims and religious minorities which prevented a fundamental modernization of Middle Eastern society according to middle-class ideals (Göçek 1996). As a result of such religious polarity, the will to social reform was more and more eclipsed by the emergence of Arab nationalism in the interwar years.

The *Effendis* in Egypt, who shared many cultural similarities with the European middle classes, not least their quest for sociocultural modernization, remained closely linked to the rural hinterland from which many of them originated. According to Lucie Ryzova (2014), the only distinction between the *effendi*, a somewhat educated urban figure in suits, and the *ibn al-balad*, the traditionally clothed urban figure with a rural background, was precisely the former figure’s claim to modernity. After Britain unilaterally declared the independence of Egypt in 1922, the *effendis* became important in politics and the public service, even though Egypt had become a kingdom. They had, however, always to consider the opinion of the peasantry and the urban poor. For instance, they had to be rather cautious in their effort for ending the practice of veiling as members of the under-middle class and the Egyptian underclass considered unveiling a Western practice and reckoned it was against Islamic instruction (Badran 2000).

Similar, though delayed, processes can be observed in sub-Saharan Africa after the Second World War. As in India, African nationalist leaders often came from indigenous middle classes which emerged in the interwar years and whose members acquired a Western education in missionary schools and/or Western universities (West 2002; Hunter 2019). Many of them did not advocate for decolonization until the 1940s. Senegalese anti-colonialist Léopold Senghor for instance, one of the leading figures in the literary movement of *Négritude*, rather argued for the cultural unity of a Francophone world and emphasized the vision of a relation on equal footing between France and its colonies within a federal organization of Empire (Wilder 2005). Yet, the interwar years saw the consolidation of an African middle class in many countries and the deployment of an anticolonial repertoire of ideas that

could be mobilized after 1945. After the Second World War, anticolonial mobilization in sub-Saharan Africa relied on both the activities of Western-educated elites (*i.e.*, the middle classes), and the agitation of the rural population. The relation between these two social strata was far from harmonious. As Elizabeth Schmidt (2005) explained with reference to Guinea, the elites often showed themselves shocked by sexually explicit songs with which subaltern women from the *Rassemblement Démocratique Africain* mocked their political opponents. She thus argues that anticolonial nationalism should be considered a conjunction between top-down- and bottom-up-processes and suggests that such an approach could be used as a methodological tool for the examination of national mobilization strategies in the colonial world.

Taken together, the crisis of European colonial rule and the breakdown of the Ottoman Empire, both of which were consequences of the Great War, affected the social order throughout the Global South. Everywhere, national independence movements emerged or grew in strength, and middle-class activists claimed a leading role. However, they had to establish new coalitions with subaltern groups, which were always rather fragile due to cultural disparities and different economic goals of the respective classes. Whilst in all areas of the colonial world, the interwar years were an era of change, this did not have the same form and effect in all world areas. Whereas in South Asia, the activities of the independence movement were successful in ending colonial rule after the end of the Second World War, the same was true in sub-Saharan Africa only in the 1950s and 1960s. The differing pace and progress of interwar anti-colonialism of the global middle classes indicate that the interwar years were not a distinct epoch in terms of establishing nation states in the Global South. Instead, they were part of a longer process that saw imperial power wane and the concomitant transformation of local societies.

The Different Fate of the Middle Classes in Japan and China

The interwar years also affected the middle classes in East Asia. Yet, according to political and economic conditions, they did so in a rather different manner. In Japan, an urban middle class emerged in the wake of the Meiji Restoration, a product of the political stability and the policy of socioeconomic modernization initiated by the Tennō after the 1860s. Even earlier, an urban proto-bourgeoisie had induced economic reforms after the seventeenth century with the effect that the discrepancy between rural and urban areas was rather small, which facilitated the social modernization of the country after the late nineteenth century (Pratt 1999). As a consequence, “Japan witnessed in the early twentieth century the emergence of a social stratum that can be defined as middle class in terms of its materialist values and its attitudes and aspirations” as Janet Hunter (2019, 166) has argued. The interwar years saw this group grow considerably. The economic boom of the First World War and the rapid expansion of urbanization that followed led to the appearance of new patterns of consumer culture, and this group is estimated to have grown from 4% of the total population in 1915 to 12% by 1925 (Ambaras 1998; Gordon 2002; Satō 2003). Scholars have argued that it might be useful to distinguish between an “old” middle class of small-scale business owners, manufacturers, and landowners, and “new” middle classes consisting of professionals and intellectuals who were associated with the growth of Western-style education, white-collar employment, and the expansion of urban commerce and culture industries (Young 2013, 5). A similar distinction has been suggested for other areas such as British India (Markovits 2008) or Persia, where the emergence of a Western-educated middle class was a consequence of educational reforms initiated by the Shah after the turn of the twentieth century in order to modernize the country (Schayegh 2009; Chehabi 2019).

Even though members of the Japanese middle class were highly visible in urban centers, their political influence was rather weak in the interwar period compared to both metropolitan societies and colonial dependencies where middle-class intellectuals played an important role in anticolonial independence movements. It is important to note, however, that in the 1870s, a bourgeois protest movement challenged the authoritarian regime of the Japanese state and aimed for the establishment of a constitutional monarchy and freedom of opinion. This movement failed, however, and the Japanese state remained organized in a rather hierarchic and autocratic manner and aligned to the sovereignty of the Tennō. Due to the rise of nationalist and expansionist tendencies, proponents of a liberal society became ever more marginalized after the turn of the century. Nevertheless, there remained a definable core of Japanese liberalism in the interwar period, mostly consisting of middle-class intellectuals advocating for freedom of expression and an expansion of popular participation in politics (Siniawer 2011; Foljanty-Jost and Hüstebeck 2013). It was arguably only after the 1970s that with the rise of new protest movements, such as the women's or the ecological movement, respectively, that civil society actors began to have a considerable influence on Japanese politics (Mae 2013). This was facilitated not least by the fact that the Japanese middle class was considered the agent of social renaissance after 1945. This social stratum increased considerably as economic growth began once more to gather pace in the afterwar years; as a consequence, in the 1960s, about 90% of all Japanese ranked themselves among the social group of the middle class (Zunz 2002, 3; Chiavacci 2008).

The development of the middle class in China differed remarkably from that of Japan. In China as well, a new middle stratum emerged after the mid-nineteenth century as the opening-up of the country by European imperialism offered the Chinese mercantile community new possibilities for cooperation with Western businessmen (Hao 1970). At the same time, a new intelligentsia established itself in treaty ports such as Shanghai, whose members had received a Western education in missionary schools and at European or American universities. The treaty ports were essential to the emergence of this social group, as it was the first time in Chinese history that cities were not mere objects of state governance but sites in which new political initiatives were established (Osterhammel 2002). As a consequence, the emerging urban middle class known as *shenshang* (scholars and merchants) distinguished themselves ever more from Confucian notions of social order. They were united by new cultural virtues and emphasized notions such as pragmatism, modernity, or nationalism. In particular, after the Xinhai Revolution of 1911, the institution of a liberal society seemed to be a realistic option within the newly established Republic of China. The economic crisis after 1923, however, brought an end to “the Golden Age of the Chinese Bourgeoisie” (as this period was labeled by Marie-Claire Bergère) and initiated a period of more than two decades of political turmoil and civil war that only ended with the takeover of the Communist Party in 1949 (Bergère 1989). The Chinese middle class had been considerably weakened by the civil war and was systematically eradicated in the People's Republic after 1949 (Osterhammel and Dabringhaus 2019).

Yves Chevrier (2010) argued that the main reason for the political failure of the Chinese middle class was the fact that their influence was confined to the cosmopolitan micro-cosmos of coastal towns. They had only few connections to the Chinese hinterland and the peasantry, which constituted the vast majority of the Chinese population. What is more, they had no decisive influence on state bureaucracy and there were only weak ties between the educated middle class and the economic bourgeoisie. As a consequence, the coastal intelligentsia was never able to devise a political program for social modernization on a national level and became hapless victims of the domestic conflicts of the interwar years.

When we draw a comparison between China and Japan, two factors were arguably crucial for the fact that Japanese society was successful in social modernization and the middle class could establish itself as a social group in the long run. The first difference was that the Japanese Emperor took on social modernization as a state task after the 1860s and that he could establish social reforms due to relative stability of domestic social and political order. In China, the influence of the court was much weaker and traditional structures survived much longer, a product of the size and the ethnic diversity of China. Thus, the Chinese territory was much more difficult to control, which is why reforms could be established only after the Communists had seized power in 1949. A second difference resulted from different developments in the countryside before the late nineteenth century. In Japan, an agrarian middle class and a group of rural entrepreneurs had emerged that could establish economic structures that were compatible with social changes after the late nineteenth century, which was not the case in China. The establishment of such structures was crucial as they stood not in contradiction to industrialization and the moral code of urban middle classes but could adapt these challenges onto rural society.

The Americas: Contestation between Bourgeoisie and Middle Classes

In European social history, the concepts of middle class and bourgeoisie are generally used as synonyms to designate the social group that is ranked between the aristocracy and the laboring classes (Kocka 2004). Historical accounts referring to the Americas, in contrast, make a clear distinction between the two concepts: the term “bourgeoisie” is generally used to describe the *Wirtschaftsbürgertum* consisting of merchants, bankers, industrial magnates, and owners of large estates, whereas “middle class” designates the *Bildungsbürgertum* of professionals, white-collar workers, scholars, or writers. These two groups had formed a coalition to oppose the predominance of the aristocracy and the claims of the emerging working class in many European countries. Scholars working on the history of North and South America instead emphasize the differences between these two social strata. For the United States, scholars have pointed out that the economic bourgeoisie became the social elite in the nineteenth century due to the lack of an aristocratic upper class (Beckert 2001; Beckert and Rosenbaum 2010; Gräser 2019). This hegemony, however, was challenged by an urban petty bourgeoisie after the turn of the twentieth century. Arguably, the boundaries between this middle class and the working class were rather fluid and much less pronounced in the United States than in Western Europe (Bledstein and Johnston 2001; Johnston 2003).

There was, however, a distinct boundary within the American middle class in terms of race. After emancipation in 1865, an African-American bourgeoisie emerged; some of its exponents acquired huge wealth after the 1870s (Graham 1999). Other African-Americans strove to gain social distinction by means of education and adhering to European bourgeois culture. A prominent example is, of course, W.E.B. Du Bois, who propagated the idea in the interwar years that emancipation could be attained by the establishment of a *Talented Tenth*, i.e., an intellectual elite of college-educated African American men who could act as role models and leaders of the Black community (Du Bois 1903). But however hard African Americans tried, they could not overcome racist prejudices. Following their rejection by the white American middle class, they reacquainted themselves to the African-American underclass, the very group from which they had aimed to distance themselves in the first place (Muraskin 1975).

The rift between white and black middle classes would not begin to diminish until the 1960s. The economic discrepancy between the economic elite of the bourgeoisie and the rest

of society, in contrast, decreased significantly after the reforms of the New Deal. The New Deal was a reaction to the Great Depression, a crisis that had its causes in the speculative boom of the 1920s—a boom that had been triggered not least by the influx of monies from European nations that had racked up debts with the United States during the war. The economic uncertainty that US society in general and many members of the middle class had to face in the interwar years can thus also be construed as an aftereffect of the Great War. The period from the mid-1930s onward saw a remarkable improvement of the economic prospects of the (white) middle class within US society. After 1945, the economic boom of the postwar years resulted in a further advancement of the living conditions of the middle class, whose situation however began to deteriorate again after the neoliberal turn in American politics in the 1980s (Harvey 2005, 17; Piketty 2014, 24).

In Latin America, there was a similar difference between an economic elite—which has been designated as bourgeoisie, aristocracy, or oligarchy, respectively—and the *clase media* (Parker and Walker 2013). Even though after the mid-nineteenth century, between 10 and 40% of the population has been ranked among the middle classes (the numbers vary depending on the method of counting, and the period and country in question), this social group never succeeded in achieving a political leading position that could be compared to the influence of the middle classes in Western Europe or North America. Latin American intellectuals time and again bemoaned this situation and went to great lengths to diagnose the causes for this situation (Parker 2019). Historians have identified the weak position of the middle classes compared to that of the oligarchy (involving owners of large estates, mines, bankers, and members of the mercantile elite) as the major reason for the lack in socioeconomic progress and the virulent militarism on the Latin American continent in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. In contrast to European social history, where a shared cultural horizon and a political coalition vis-à-vis both the aristocracy and socialist workers unified the upper and middle classes to become a European bourgeoisie, studies on Latin America emphasize the difference between bourgeoisie/oligarchy and (lower) middle classes. As a result, neither a stable democracy nor a strong civil society could be established; the oligarchy did not rely on a coalition with other parts of society but could resort to military power to grind down the claims of the peasantry and the working classes (Grandin 2004).

In contrast to other parts of the world, it seems that the interwar period did not bring a remarkable shift in the social position of the Latin American middle classes. Rather, the period between the late nineteenth and the late twentieth century was defined by political crisis and military coups (Fowler 1996). This situation is remarkably different from that of the first half of the nineteenth century when, after the end of Spanish colonial rule, politics in the newly independent Latin American republics were characterized by a remarkable degree of reconciliation and by the establishment of political institutions that were much more advanced than those in Europe at the same time. In Colombia, for instance, universal male suffrage was introduced in 1853 that gave men of any ethnic group the right to vote. This could be achieved not least due to a coalition of liberals coming from both popular and elite circles. The failure of republican and democratic movements after the mid-nineteenth century resulted not from a disinterest of subaltern groups in national politics, as scholars suggested for a long time. Rather it was a consequence of the fact that Latin America took up a new position in the world economy. As James Sanders (2009) argued, the Latin American economy became ever more dependent on the export of commodities such as coffee, banana, ore, and guano to Western Europe and the United States. As a consequence, the political standing of Latin American elites did no longer depend on political arrangements with subalterns or middle-class liberals but rather on support of neo-colonial powers from the global

North. At the same time, the economic bourgeoisie could use the infrastructure of the newly constructed railways and telegraph lines to contain the underclasses. In the interwar years, the ideology of fascism became popular among many members of both the elite and the middle classes and brought about another wave of authoritarian rule in many Latin American countries (Pinto 2021). It was only in the wake of the economic boom of the 1990s that resulted once more in an improvement of the situation of the Latin American middle classes (Ferreira et al. 2013). Whether this will result in the establishment of a stable civil society or whether such hopes will once more collapse due to the internal contradictions of the continent remains however to be seen.

Conclusion

As these varied examples suggest, the First World War was indeed an event that influenced societies around the globe and, more specifically, altered the social position of the middle classes in many countries. In Europe, many contemporaries were convinced that the war had resulted in a decline of bourgeois society, which arguably had been replaced by mass politics and mass culture. In the overseas colonies of European empires, the interwar years brought about the rise of national independence movements, many of which saw middle-class activists claim a leading role. The middle classes could thus be both the proponents of social change and its victims. The latter was the case for instance in China where the civil war and the takeover of the Communist Party in 1949 resulted in an annihilation of the coastal middle class that had established itself in treaty ports after the late nineteenth century. Likewise, in Latin America, it was arguably the position of the continent in the world economy that stabilized the hegemony of the bourgeois upper class and doomed the attempts of the (lower) middle classes for social and political reforms. Even though the developments in the respective countries were largely influenced by local conditions in terms of governance, social relations, and economic structures, they were also affected by global processes such as imperialism, capitalism, and the Great War. This comparative examination of the bourgeois middle classes offers a lens to better understand the social and political transformations that took place across the globe and to assess the relationship between global processes and local conditions in the interwar years.

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